

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART TWO · CRAFT

CHAPTER 6 · SOUND

*Half of every film is something you hear, and most of it
you never notice.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

No Country for Old Men · 2007 · 122 min · written and directed
by Joel & Ethan Coen · from the novel by Cormac McCarthy

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

Two crime films with gunfights, getaways and a man who will not stop coming. They sound nothing alike. No Country for Old Men has almost no music: wind, footsteps, a hum from a motel light, the hiss of a gas canister, and silence doing the work a score usually does.

Baby Driver is cut entirely to its soundtrack, with the car turns, the footsteps and even the gunshots landing on the beat of whatever is playing in the hero's ears. One takes the music away. The other makes everything music.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

NO COUNTRY FOR OLD MEN

2007 · 122 min · written and directed by Joel & Ethan Coen · from the novel by Cormac McCarthy

A Texas hunter stumbles on a drug deal gone wrong and walks off with two million dollars. A killer with a cattle gun comes after him, and an ageing sheriff trails behind them both.

Why it is on the ballot. It is one of the quietest thrillers ever made and one of the tensest. With almost no score to tell you how to feel, every small sound becomes a threat: a wrapper crinkling, a receiver beeping, footsteps stopping outside a door.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THERE IS A SCORE. YOU JUST WILL NOT HEAR IT

Carter Burwell's own note on the film reads: "Including end credits, there are a mere 16 minutes of music in the film." He built most of it from singing bowls — metal bowls rubbed to hold one long tone — and worked with the sound team so the music hides inside the effects: "The sounds are snuck in underneath the wind or the sound of a car. When the wind or car goes away, the sound is left behind, but you never hear it appear."

THE SILENCE IS DESIGNED BY HAND

Skip Lievsay was supervising sound editor, with Craig Berkey as sound designer and re-recording mixer. The quiet is not an absence of sound work: it is hundreds of small sounds placed so carefully you never catch them being placed.

LISTEN FOR THE WEAPON

The killer carries a captive bolt pistol, the air-powered tool used in slaughterhouses, fed by a tank he carries with him. Its hiss and thud is one of the most recognisable sounds in modern film. You will read online that it was built from a nail gun; no interview with the sound team says so, so treat that as rumour.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE OPENING

Wind

An old man talks over empty West Texas landscapes. No music, only wind.

Why it matters: The film tells you in the first minute what it will sound like. You are going to have to listen.

THE GAS STATION

The coin

A killer and a shop owner talk across a counter. Listen to the wrapper, the hum, the pauses.

Why it matters: No music tells you this is the scariest scene in the film. You work it out yourself, which is worse. Burwell tuned the hum under the scene to 60 Hz, the frequency of a refrigerator's mains buzz, so the music reads as room tone.

THE MOTEL

The beeping, the light, the footsteps

A transponder starts beeping. Shoes block the strip of light under the door. The footsteps stop.

Why it matters: It is a whole action sequence built out of sound. Berkey's note on it: several things happen off screen early "that force you to focus on the smallest of sounds."

THE LAST SCENE

No swell

The film ends with a man at a kitchen table describing a dream about his father carrying fire through a cold dark pass. "And then I woke up." Cut to black.

Why it matters: A score would tell you how to feel about that. The Coens refuse, and the silence afterwards is the loudest thing in the film.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

Burwell tried more music and threw it out

He experimented with violin harmonics and percussion, and cut them: they “destroyed the tension that came from the quiet.”

OPEN

The Academy noticed the sound

Eight nominations, four wins — Picture, Director, Adapted Screenplay and Supporting Actor for Javier Bardem — plus nominations for both Sound Editing and Sound Mixing.

OPEN

The title is a poem, and the date is usually wrong

“That is no country for old men” opens W. B. Yeats’s “Sailing to Byzantium,” written in 1926 and first published in *October Blast* in 1927, before it was collected in *The Tower* in 1928.

01 Without music telling you how to feel, where did your tension come from?

02 Which sound from the film is still in your head?

03 The ending refuses both a showdown and a score. Did you feel cheated, or haunted?

Where to watch

Find it here → [No Country for Old Men on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

THE LESSON

HEARD, NOT NOTICED

THREE SOVIET DIRECTORS SAW IT COMING

In 1928, as synchronised sound arrived, Sergei Eisenstein, Vsevolod Pudovkin and Grigori Alexandrov published a short “Statement on Sound.” They warned that sound would be used for “talking films” — recorded theatre — which would destroy the art of the cut, and argued for the opposite: “Only a contrapuntal use of sound in relation to the visual montage piece will afford a new potentiality of montage development and perfection.”

HOLLYWOOD DID THE OPPOSITE

The studios synchronised everything — every line, every door, every footstep — and composers like Max Steiner laid a lush orchestral score underneath that followed the feeling of every scene. The working rule became: the audience should feel the music, not hear it. A good score was one nobody noticed.

THE RULE GOT ITS NAME LATER

In 1987 the scholar Claudia Gorbman set out the principles of classical Hollywood scoring in *Unheard Melodies*. One of them is inaudibility: music is not meant to be heard consciously. She was describing a habit, not prescribing one, but the phrase stuck, and the habit is still the default in most films you watch.

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN USE SOUND

ONE

MATCH IT

Sound follows the picture and the score follows the feeling. You never think about it.

Almost everything

TWO

TAKE IT AWAY

Little or no score, so small sounds and silence carry the tension.

No Country for Old Men · A Quiet Place · The Birds

THREE

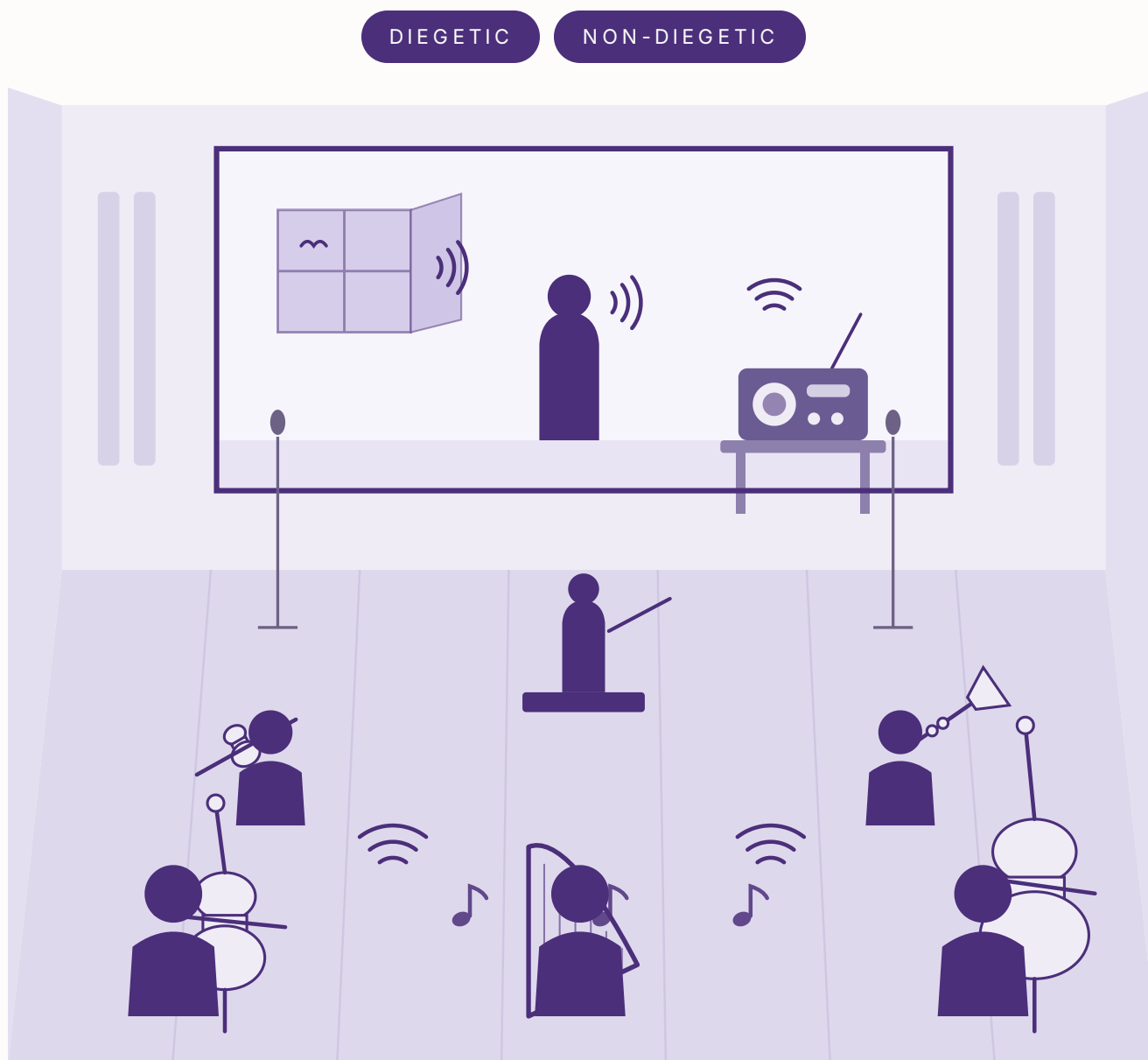
LET IT DRIVE

The music comes first and the picture is cut to it.

Baby Driver · Whiplash · Guardians of the Galaxy

The third one is rare: it requires obtaining song rights before a frame is shot.

IN THE SCENE VS. IN THE SCREEN



Diegetic sound has a source inside the world: the radio playing, the bird through the open window, the man's own voice. He could switch any of it off. Non-diegetic sound is laid over that world from outside it — a score played by musicians who are not in the room and never will be. To tell them apart, ask whether anything in the shot could stop the sound.

The frame is the border, which is why *Baby Driver* is such a strange case: its songs are diegetic, playing in Baby's earbuds, and they do the job of a score at the same time.

Room tone is a third thing again — the sound of a space with nobody talking. Every set records it, and *No Country for Old Men* is practically built out of it.

WHY THESE FILMS

This closes Part Two. The frame decides what you see, the cut decides when, and sound decides how it feels. One film proves how loud silence is. The other proves a film can be edited like a song.

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R. Julian Tuttle

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from Carter Burwell's project notes, Designing Sound, Criterion, Rolling Stone, CineMontage and the Academy's records. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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